

added individually as a volume, and can be renamed as you have named the CDs. Once added, the Advanced MP3 Catalog Pro stores the track details in the database. Just find the song that you wish to play in the database, and select Play. You will be told which CD to insert, and your song will play automatically in your default player.

The Groups tab lets you browse your collection by album name, year, artiste, etc. The built-in searching, and duplicate finding are also very powerful. Other features worth mentioning are a label printer that prints jewel case inserts of your MP3 discs, the ability to export lists in various formats and simple ID3 tag editing.

Advanced MP3 Catalog Pro does a great job of keeping your collection organised, especially if it's largely on a CD. It lacks in features as compared to others, but serves the purpose best, and that, with minimal effort.

Now, tag and stack it

For some things though, you just need a dedicated tool. A good example is tagging that refers to entering the relevant information into the ID3 Tags. These tags are the most popular way of maintaining the track's information, with most portable devices being capable of reading and displaying them during playback.

Use a free tool, called ID3 TagIT found at <http://www.id3-tagit.de/english/download.htm> to rename and tag MP3s. As you launch the program, a simple Explorer-style window greets you, with a directory tree in the left window. Browse to the folder that has the files you wish to edit, and click on it. All the MP3 files in the folder are read and their tag information is displayed. This may take a while, if there are many files. Ensure that you are currently viewing the ID3 tag version 2 as shown on the toolbar's top-right corner. The right pane displays a table, with the tracks and their tag's details listed. To edit the tag information of a single song, simply double-click on the song name. If you wish to edit a particular field of multiple songs simultaneously, select the tracks, and then click on 'Multiple Edit ID3 v2' on the toolbar, or press [Ctrl] + [N]. Type in the details in the field to be replaced,

for example, the artiste's name. Keep in mind that the same data will be written to all the files selected. You can also change the case of your Tags.

Once you're done, you can copy the ID3v2 tags to the ID3v1 tags for backward compatibility. Click the Transfer/Convert icon, or press [F4], to bring up the window. Here, select Transfer ID3v2 to ID3v1, and select all the fields.



You must also copy the tag information to the filename, so that your files can be easily managed in Windows Explorer. Close the program, and click on Yes to save the changes.

Ideally, you should have all your music in one folder. Within that folder, there could be subfolders for artistes, with further sub-division into albums. If you listen to a lot of music away from your PC, JRiver's Media Center can burn your

favourite tunes onto CDs, using smart lists. If you don't need this capability, Advanced MP3 Catalog will suffice to simply organise your collection.

For those with disk space, it's ideal to have all your songs on your PC itself, so that they are instantly accessible. If you can enjoy this luxury, all you have to do is scan your PC with Advanced MP3 Catalog Pro. Start the program, and click on the New icon. You will be prompted to scan your PC. Complete the scan, and you're done. Those with too many MP3s, or too little room on their hard disks, need to write their MP3s onto CD. Use your CD writing software to do this. Once you have your CDs done, you can add them in as volumes into Advanced MP3 Catalog. To do this, click the Add Volume icon, or press [Insert] on the keyboard. Select your CD drive from the browse window that comes up. Pay attention to naming the volumes, and your CDs correctly. When you run a search for a particular track, and that track is on a CD, you will be asked for that CD by the Volume name. So, if the names aren't the same, things will get confusing.

Have you ever copied tracks off a CD, only to end up with two copies of one, or more numbers? If this is a regular occurrence with you, the problem is likely to be compounded. You can search for duplicates using Advanced MP3 Catalog. Switch to the Duplicates tab, and select the basis for comparison of files to determine if they are duplicates. If your collection is large, it's recommended that you search one criterion at a time. Start with File Size, as it's the best way to determine exact duplicates. Click Start to begin searching. You will be presented with a list of possible duplicates. Compare the files visually by their file name and select one of each. Use [Ctrl] to select multiple files. Once you're done, review your selection, and press [Ctrl] + [Delete] to remove them.

So there it is, and easier than you thought! With just a little know-how, and your good old PC, you can resurrect your musical past, and blend it into your organised musical future. Sounds good, doesn't it? 

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